Keeper of Heritage

ABHA NARAIN LAMBAH'S OEUVRE IS monumental—literally. As a celebrated conservation architect, her tours de force span India's heritage landscape. From the Buddhist sites of Ajanta in Maharashtra and Bodh Gaya in Bihar, regional conservation in Kancheepuram in Tamil Nadu and Shekhawati in Rajasthan, to 20th-century modern heritage in Corbusier's Chandigarh—her unique approach can be found stamped on these iconic symbols of India's golden past. "The glass ceiling is in your head," says Lambah, who was born to an author mother and a bureaucrat father. "I consciously defied all stereotypes associated with being a woman."

In 1998, she set up Abha Narain Lambah Associates, which specialises in architectural conservation, building restoration and retrofit, museum design, historic interiors, preparation of urban- and regional-level conservation management plans, conservation assessment studies, urban signage and street furniture. And, it has won nine UNESCO Asia Pacific Awards for conservation projects. "We are the largest conservation practice in South Asia," says Abha, who has been honoured with the Sanskriti Award, the Eisenhower Fellowship, the Attingham Trust Fellowship and the Charles Wallace Fellowship, among many others.

Abha Narain Lambah, *53*
Conservation architect; principal architect and founder, Abha Narain Lambah Associates

She has been a consultant to several organisations, including ICCROM, UNITAR, World Monuments Fund, Global Heritage Fund and Archaeological Survey of India, and has served on the heritage committees of both Delhi and Mumbai.

Abha's hands-on approach to work often takes her to her sites. But it is a bonus that she loves to travel. "I have zero work-life balance, but I am happy. Every day, I wake up excited to go to work," she says. She continues to shatter the proverbial glass ceiling just by being who she is. "When I was a student 35 years ago, there were barely any girls in architecture studies. The whole concept was that it was a very masculine profession. After graduating, I was very clear that I would establish a woman-led practice," says Abha, whose daughter Ambika is also studying architecture.

"The other stereotype is that women are only good for interiors and decoration. In my 25 years, I haven't done even one residential interior project. I did not want to be placed in a box." We couldn't agree more. ■

–Ridhi Kale

ACCOMPLISHMENT

She has been instrumental in conserving several landmark heritage sites, monuments and museums across India



MANDAR DEODHAR

ADVICE TO WOMEN

"The glass ceiling is in your own head. I consciously defied all stereotypes one associates with being a woman"

WHAT'S HELPED HER ON THE JOB

Stubbornness. "I am very persistent... In fact, my team calls me delusionally optimistic"